SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Going Paperless

A practical plan to cut the clutter and keep your records safe — for Canadian small businesses

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Going Paperless — A practical plan to cut the clutter and keep your records safe — for Canadian small businesses

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Important. This guide is general information for Canadian small-business owners. It is not legal, tax, accounting, or financial advice, and it does not create a professional relationship of any kind. Rules, rates, forms, and software features change. Before you act, check the official source named in the guide and, where the stakes are real, talk to a qualified professional who knows your situation.

Nothing in this guide is legal, tax, or accounting advice. Record-keeping rules are set by the Canada Revenue Agency and privacy rules by federal and provincial law, and both can change — check the official guidance before you destroy any original records.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

This guide is for Canadian small-business owners who are tired of shoeboxes, glove-box receipts, and the drawer nobody wants to open. It is written for sole proprietors and small teams: trades, cleaners, salons, consultants, photographers, landscapers, tutors, food trucks, and small shops. You do not need to be good with computers. You need a phone, a computer or tablet, and some patience for the first few weeks.

It covers what “paperless” can realistically mean, how to take stock of your paper, what the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA) expects from your records, a folder and file-naming system, scanning and receipt habits, digital invoices, payments, contracts and forms, cloud storage and privacy, security and backups, what to keep on paper, and a four-week rollout schedule with a monthly routine. Read the chapters in order the first time through. After that, the Checklist and the monthly routine are the pages you will likely come back to.

This is not legal or tax advice

This guide is general information, not legal, tax, or accounting advice. Record-keeping rules come from the CRA and, for some records, your province. Privacy rules come from federal and provincial law. Those rules can change, and your situation may have details this guide cannot cover. Before you destroy original records or change how you keep your books, check the CRA’s guidance at canada.ca/revenue-agency and talk to your accountant or bookkeeper.

Software changes quickly too. Tools are described in general terms. Any product names are examples only, not recommendations. Check the current version of any tool before you rely on it.

How to use the worksheets

The Templates chapter holds a paper audit worksheet, a folder structure, a naming rules card, a scan-day checklist, a security checklist, a backup log, and a retention notes sheet. The four-week plan is in its own chapter. Print them or copy them into a document or spreadsheet, and fill each one in while the matching chapter is fresh.

> **TIP**
>
> You do not have to do everything at once. Pick one kind of paper — receipts are a good start — and get that working before you move on.

What paperless really means

"Paperless" sounds like a switch you flip. In real life it is a direction. Some paper will always come through the door: a supplier who only mails invoices, a customer who pays by cheque, a government letter, a signed document you should keep in its original form.

A better goal: **paper is a temporary state.** When paper arrives, you capture it into your digital system soon. Then it is either filed in one small, labelled place for paper you keep, or destroyed safely once you are sure you no longer need the original.

Going paperless can make it easier to find a receipt when your bookkeeper asks, to answer a customer question from your phone, and to produce records if the CRA asks. It can also reduce the risk of losing everything to a flood or fire. It is not free: setting up takes time, you may pay for a scanner or software, and you take on new risks, like a hacked email account or a lost laptop. Later chapters help you manage those, step by step, without needing technical training.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a two-person cleaning business in Truro. Receipts go into an envelope in the van, invoices come from a carbon-copy book, and customer keys are tracked on a sheet taped inside a cupboard. A realistic goal: receipts photographed the same day, invoices emailed from accounting software, and the key list kept in a password-protected document. The carbon-copy book can retire, and the envelope becomes a "to scan" folder that empties every Friday.

Take stock: the paper audit

Before you buy anything, find out what paper you actually deal with. This is the paper audit. Walk through your workspace, vehicle, and home office with the paper audit worksheet from the Templates chapter, and look at three streams:

1. **Paper coming in:** supplier invoices, receipts, bank and card statements, customer cheques, government mail, insurance documents, signed quotes.
2. **Paper going out:** quotes, invoices, receipts you give customers, contracts, work orders, intake forms.
3. **Paper you store:** filing cabinets, basement boxes, binders, the glove box, the "important" drawer at home.

For each item, note how often it happens, whether it could arrive or leave in digital form, who handles it today, and whether you need the original or a good scan would do. If you are unsure about that last one, write "check" and come back after the next chapter.

Decide where to start

Look for the paper that shows up most often and causes the most frustration. That might be receipts and supplier bills, then invoices to customers, then old stored files. The aim is to stop new paper piling up first. The old boxes can wait for calm, scheduled sessions later.

It also helps to decide what “done” looks like for your first target, in plain words. For receipts, it might be: “Every business receipt is photographed within a day, named, and in the right folder by Friday.” A clear finish line makes it easier to tell whether the new habit is working, and easier to explain to anyone who helps you. Once that first target runs smoothly for a few weeks without much thought, pick the next one from your audit list. Moving one kind of paper at a time keeps the change small enough to fit around paying work.

What you will need

You probably own most of it already. The basics are a phone with a scanning feature or app, one place for your files (cloud storage, or a computer that is backed up), a password manager, and an external drive or second service for backups. Optional extras include a document scanner for batches, a shredder, and a fire-resistant box for the originals you keep. Before you buy anything, finish the paper audit. It will show you what you actually need, and you may find a phone and a good routine cover most of it. If you do buy hardware or software, keep the receipt and file it in your new system. It makes a good first test of your naming rules.

KEY POINTS

- Paperless means less paper and a reliable system, not zero paper.
- Treat paper as temporary: capture it, then file it or destroy it.
- Audit what comes in, what goes out, and what you store.
- Start with the paper that shows up most often. Leave the old boxes for later.

What the CRA expects from your records

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> This chapter is general information, not tax advice. Read the CRA's guidance on keeping records at canada.ca/revenue-agency and talk to your accountant before you destroy any original documents.

How long and in what form

The CRA generally requires you to keep your books and records for **six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to**. Confirm the current rule on the CRA's "keeping records" pages. Records include sales invoices, receipts, bank statements, contracts, and the documents behind the numbers in your tax and GST/HST returns. Note the wording: the clock runs from the end of the last tax year the record relates to, not the date on the receipt. A record that supports something claimed over several years, such as equipment, may need to be kept longer. Ask your accountant how this applies to you.

Electronic records are acceptable. The CRA has rules for keeping electronic records and for imaging, the official word for scanning paper records. Your records must be readable and available if the CRA asks for them. In practice:

- A blurry photo where you cannot read the total or date may not do the job.
- A pile of files named `IMG_4471.jpg` is digital but not organized.
- Keep files in common formats, such as PDF, that you can open years from now.
- If a record started out digital, such as an emailed invoice, keep the digital original, not only a printout.

Check before you shred

The most important habit in this chapter: **check the CRA's current guidance on keeping records and imaging before you shred original paper**, and ask your accountant whether your scanning process is good enough to rely on. Until then, scan and keep. Store the originals in a box labelled by year. A lost original cannot be undone.

Questions for your accountant: Is my scanning process good enough to destroy the originals? Are there records I should keep on paper, or keep longer than six years? Does it matter where my cloud provider stores my files? How do you want records handed over?

Receipts and input tax credits

If you are registered for GST/HST, you can generally claim back the GST/HST you paid on business purchases as input tax credits (ITCs), if you have the required documentation. What a receipt must show depends on the total, in tiers: under $100; $100 to under $500; and $500 or more. More details are required at each tier — for example, the supplier's GST/HST registration number from the $100 tier, and the buyer's name, payment terms, and a description at the $500 tier. Check the CRA's guidance for the exact list.

So your scan must capture **the whole receipt**: supplier, date, GST/HST number, tax amount, and total. A photo that cuts off the bottom of a long receipt can cut off exactly what you need. A GST/HST number looks like 123456789 RT0001 (an obviously made-up example): nine digits, RT, and four digits.

Paper to keep, and paper to destroy

Some documents are worth keeping in original form, at least until you have checked with a professional: signed leases and loan agreements, partnership or shareholder agreements, incorporation papers and minute books, property and vehicle titles, wills and powers of attorney, and anything a law, lender, insurer, or government body tells you to keep. Keep them together in a fire-resistant box or one labelled drawer, and scan a working copy.

When you have confirmed you no longer need a paper original, and a good scan is stored and backed up, destroy it securely:

- **Shred, do not recycle whole.** A cross-cut shredder makes small pieces that are harder to reassemble than strips.
- **For large volumes**, a document destruction company can help. Ask whether they provide a certificate of destruction.
- **Keep a destruction log**: what you destroyed, the date range it covered, when, and how. The retention notes sheet has space for this.

KEY POINTS

- The CRA generally requires records to be kept six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to. Confirm at canada.ca/revenue-agency.
- Electronic and scanned records are acceptable if readable and available on request.
- Check the CRA's imaging guidance and ask your accountant before shredding originals.
- Capture the whole receipt, including the GST/HST number and tax.
- Keep key originals in one safe place, shred the rest, and log it.

Folders, file names, and scanning

A simple folder structure

A good folder structure matters more than which app you use. If files are well organized, you can move them to another service later without getting lost. The test: **someone else should be able to find a file without asking you** — your bookkeeper, a new employee, or a family member if you are away.

Keep it shallow. Three levels is usually enough.

Top folder	What goes in it	Inside, organize by
01 Admin	Registrations, licences, insurance	Topic
02 Sales	Quotes, invoices, customer contracts	Year, then month
03 Purchases	Supplier bills, receipts	Year, then month
04 Banking	Bank and credit card statements	Year
05 Tax	GST/HST and income tax, CRA letters	Year
06 Payroll	Pay records, remittances, T4s	Year
07 Staff	Employee files (restricted)	Person
08 Customers	Customer files, signed forms	Customer
99 Inbox	New scans waiting to be filed	Empty it weekly

Numbers at the start keep folders in the same order on every device. The “99 Inbox” is where new scans and downloads land before you name and file them.

A file-naming convention

A naming convention is a set of rules for naming files so they sort sensibly and you can tell what a file is without opening it. A pattern that works well is **Date_Who_What-Number.pdf**:

- **Date** first, as year-month-day, so files sort by date on their own.
- **Who**: the vendor or customer, short, with no spaces.
- **What**: Invoice, Receipt, Quote, Contract, Statement, Letter.
- **Number**: the invoice or reference number, if there is one.

Examples: `2026-11-04_Vendor_Invoice-1234.pdf`, `2026-11-04_HarbourFuels_Receipt.pdf`, `2026-11-06_SmithJ_Quote-Q0412.pdf`, `2026-11-30_Chequing_Statement.pdf`.

Use underscores between parts and hyphens within a part. Avoid spaces and symbols like `#` or `&`, which some systems handle badly. Keep one spelling for each regular vendor; a short vendor list taped beside your desk helps. Never use “final” or “new” in a name. Use `v2`, `v3` instead, so you can always tell which version is the latest.

Email deserves a word of its own. Emailed invoices and receipts are easy to receive and easy to lose. An email account can be closed, hacked, or simply too full to search well, and it is hard to hand an inbox to your bookkeeper. Make it a habit to save important attachments out of email and into your folders, named with your convention. Some accounting and receipt tools can pull bills in from a dedicated email address. That can help, but you still need to know where those records end up and how to export them.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you are a landscaper in Bridgewater. A fuel receipt from November 4, 2026 goes in `03 Purchases/2026/2026-11` as `2026-11-04_HarbourFuels_Receipt.pdf`, next to the mulch invoice and the mower parts bill.

Phone app or scanner

Phone scanning apps — often built into the phone’s camera, notes, or files app, or into accounting and expense tools — crop and straighten the page and save a PDF. Some read the vendor, date, and total for you. They suit receipts and single pages on the go.

A sheet-feed document scanner scans a stack of pages, both sides, in one pass. It suits backlogs and multi-page documents. A flatbed scanner is slower but handles fragile or bound items. Many businesses use a phone for daily receipts and a scanner for monthly batches. Check reviews and current versions before you buy, and check whether an app keeps copies of your files on its own servers.

Helpful settings: save documents as **PDF**; turn on **text recognition** (OCR, optical character recognition) so you can search inside scans; use **colour or greyscale** for faint stamps and receipts; and choose a resolution where the smallest print is clear when you zoom in.

Quality checks and receipt habits

A scan you cannot read is not a record. Check each one: date, vendor, total, and tax readable; all edges and pages present; named and filed. For receipts of $100 or more, or $500 or more, check that the extra details the CRA requires at that tier are visible. Thermal receipts, the shiny cash-register kind, can fade, so scan them soon rather than at tax time.

Habits worth trying:

- **Capture at the point of purchase.** Photograph the receipt before you start the car, then put the paper in one “to file” pouch.
- **Add a note** if your app allows: “Brackets for Jones deck.”

- **Ask for email receipts** and send them to one business-only address.
- **Set a weekly filing time** to name files and empty the inbox folder.
- **Keep the paper** in a monthly envelope until you have confirmed you may destroy it.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Say you run a mobile dog-grooming van in Moncton. You photograph each supply receipt before leaving the store, add a one-word note (“supplies”), and drop the paper into a monthly envelope. On Fridays you check the photos are clear and named.

Clearing the backlog

Old boxes of paper are tempting to tackle in one heroic weekend. You may find short, scheduled sessions easier to stick with. Book an hour or two in your calendar, take one box, and use the scan-day checklist in the Templates chapter. Start with the most recent year, since that is the one you are most likely to need. Older years can follow at whatever pace suits your season.

Before you scan, sort. Pull out anything that belongs in your “keep the original” box, anything that is clearly personal rather than business, and duplicates such as a second copy of the same statement. Then scan what is left, one month or one category at a time, so each batch lands in a single folder. When a box is done, label it with what is inside and the date you scanned it, and put it back in storage until you have confirmed what you may destroy.

You may find that some old records are already past the period you need to keep them. Do not assume. Confirm with your accountant before shredding, and note the decision on your retention notes sheet.

> KEY POINTS
>
> - Organize so someone else could find a file without asking you.
> - Keep folders shallow and numbered, with a 99 Inbox you empty weekly.
> - Name files Date_Who_What-Number, with the date as year-month-day.
> - Use a phone for daily receipts and a scanner for batches; check every scan.
> - Capture receipts the same day and keep a weekly filing time.

Invoices, payments, contracts, and forms

Invoices and quotes

Sending quotes and invoices by email or invoicing software is often the easiest way to cut paper going out. Most invoicing tools build invoices from a template with your business details and GST/HST number (if registered), send them as a PDF or link, track what is paid, and keep a copy.

If you use a word processor or spreadsheet instead, save each invoice as a PDF with your naming convention and file it in Sales. Use numbering with no gaps, such as `INV-1042`, `INV-1043`, so you and your bookkeeper can see nothing is missing. Whatever tool you use, make sure you can **export** your records in a common format such as PDF or CSV (a simple spreadsheet format), so you can take your history with you if you switch.

Quotes deserve the same care. Save each quote you send as a PDF in the customer's folder, and when the customer accepts, save their acceptance next to it. If the job changes partway through, put the change in writing too, even a short email, and file it the same way. Then the whole story of a job sits in one place when a question comes up later.

Payments

Common options include Interac e-Transfer, card payments through a processor or point-of-sale system, and payment links in invoicing software. Fees and deposit timing differ, so compare them when you choose. For your records:

- Match each payment to an invoice. Ask customers to put the invoice number in the e-Transfer message, or use payment links that do it for you.
- Download statements and payment reports monthly and file them in Banking.
- If you still get cheques, ask your bank about mobile deposit and how long to keep the paper cheque.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Fake emails that look like they come from a real supplier sometimes ask you to pay new bank details. If a supplier says their payment details have changed, confirm by phone using a number you already have, not one in the email.

Contracts and e-signatures

Electronic signatures are generally recognized in Canada under federal and provincial electronic commerce laws, with exceptions. Some documents, such as wills, have special rules, and the exceptions vary by province. Before relying on an e-signature for something important, such as a lease or a large contract, check with a lawyer.

For everyday quotes and sign-offs, e-signature tools can be convenient. Look for a record of who signed and when (an audit trail), a signed PDF you can download into your own folders, and easy signing on a phone. For a small job, a customer replying “I accept this quote” by email, with the quote attached, gives you a written record; save both as PDFs. Whether that is enough in a given case is a legal question, so ask a lawyer when the stakes are high.

Digital forms and intake

Paper intake forms, waivers, and job sheets can often move to digital forms that customers fill in on their phone. When you set one up:

- **Collect only what you need.** Every extra question is more personal information to protect.
- **Say why you are asking** and what you will do with the answers.
- **Keep marketing consent separate.** Canada’s Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL) applies to commercial electronic messages. Booking confirmations and reminders are generally treated differently from marketing, but promotional messages need consent. Use a separate, unticked box, and ask a lawyer if unsure.
- **Know where answers land** — in the form tool, your email, or a spreadsheet — and make sure that place is secure.
- **Check signatures and waivers** with a lawyer before relying on a digital version.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a small hair salon in Charlottetown. Paper client cards hold phone numbers, colour formulas, and allergy notes. You move them into your booking software’s client profiles and add a line to your intake form explaining that colour and allergy notes are kept to provide safe service, and nothing else. The old cards go in a box until you confirm how long to keep them, then they are shredded.

KEY POINTS

- Send quotes and invoices digitally, with gap-free numbers.
- Match every payment to an invoice; file statements monthly.
- Confirm any change to a supplier’s payment details by phone.
- E-signatures are generally recognized, with exceptions. Ask a lawyer.
- Digital forms: collect only what you need; separate marketing consent.

Cloud storage, privacy, and security

Questions to ask about cloud storage

"The cloud" means your files live on another company's computers, reached over the internet. File storage services (Google Drive, Microsoft OneDrive, Dropbox, and iCloud are examples, not recommendations), online accounting, booking, and e-signature tools are all cloud software. Rather than comparing feature lists, ask:

- **Where is my data stored?** Ask your accountant whether location matters for your records.
- **Who can get in?** Can each person have their own login and limited access? Can I see who changed a file?
- **How do I get my data out?** Can I download everything in common formats? What happens to my data if I stop paying?
- **What if I delete something by mistake?** How long are deleted files and old versions kept?
- **Is it a business account?** Business plans may have different terms and controls than personal ones.

Keep business and personal files in separate accounts. It makes access, backups, and handover to your accountant much simpler.

When you share files, share carefully. Most storage services let you send a link instead of an attachment. A link can often be limited to named people, set to view-only, or set to expire, and you can turn it off later. A link that "anyone with the link" can open is convenient but can travel further than you meant it to, so save that setting for files you would not mind a stranger seeing.

Your privacy duties

PIPEDA, the federal *Personal Information Protection and Electronic Documents Act*, applies to personal information collected in commercial activity in most of Canada. Alberta, British Columbia, and Quebec have their own private-sector privacy laws. The core ideas: collect only what you need, tell people what you do with it, protect it, keep it only as long as you need it (balanced with record-keeping rules), and let people see what you hold about them if they ask.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> When you use cloud software, you remain responsible for the personal information you put into it. This is general information, not legal advice. If you handle sensitive information, such as health details, talk to a lawyer or privacy professional.

Keep sensitive files — employee records with Social Insurance Numbers or banking details, health or allergy notes, copies of ID — in a restricted folder only the right people can open. Do not email them as ordinary attachments. If you do not need a copy of something, such as a customer's ID,

do not keep one.

Passwords, devices, and staff access

- **Use a unique, strong password** for every business account. A long passphrase of several random words is easier to remember and harder to guess than a short jumble.
- **Use a password manager**, an app that creates, stores, and fills in passwords. Business versions can share specific logins with staff.
- **Turn on two-step verification** (a code from an app or a security key after your password), starting with email — whoever controls your email can often reset everything else. Store the recovery codes safely, away from your devices.
- **Lock every device** automatically, **turn on automatic updates**, and turn on encryption and "find my device" where available.
- **Be wary** of unexpected attachments, links, and urgent requests, and avoid sensitive work on public Wi-Fi.
- **Give each staff member their own login** with access only to what their job needs. A part-time cleaner may need the schedule and customer access notes, but not the payroll folder. Separate logins also let you see who did what, and remove one person without changing everyone's password.

When someone leaves, on good terms or not, act the same day:

- Remove or disable their accounts, and change any shared passwords they knew.
- Get back company devices, keys, and access cards.
- Make sure files they created are saved in shared folders, not only in their own space.
- Sign them out of company email and apps on their personal phone.

Backups: three copies, two places, one away

A backup is a separate copy you can use if the original is lost, damaged, or scrambled by ransomware (malicious software that locks your files and demands payment). Syncing is not a backup: if a file is deleted or scrambled, the sync may copy the problem everywhere. A simple habit to aim for is **three copies** of important files (the working copy plus two backups), on **two different kinds of storage** (such as your cloud service and an external drive), with **one copy away** from your premises.

Remember the data inside your cloud tools. Find out how to export from your accounting, invoicing, and booking software, and include those exports in your backups.

A backup you have never tested is a hope, not a plan. A few times a year, restore a file to a test folder, open it, and record the result in your backup log.

If something goes wrong

Plan now for a bad day, so you are not working it out under stress. If a phone or laptop is lost or stolen, use “find my device” to locate, lock, or erase it, then change the passwords for the accounts it could open, starting with email. If you suspect someone has got into your email or another account, change that password from a device you trust, check that two-step verification is still on and still yours, and look for changes you did not make, such as new forwarding rules or new payees.

If money may be involved, call your bank or payment provider right away, using the number on your card or their official website. If customer or employee information may have been exposed, privacy law can require businesses to report certain breaches and notify the people affected. The Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada’s site (priv.gc.ca) explains when that applies. This is a good moment to call a lawyer or an IT professional.

Write a short list now of who to call and where your recovery codes are, and keep it with your paper originals.

EXAMPLE

Say you are a bookkeeper working from home in Antigonish. Working files live in cloud storage. Monthly, you copy everything, plus a full export from your accounting software, to an external drive you keep at a relative’s house, swapping it with a second drive. Three copies, two kinds of storage, one away from home.

KEY POINTS

- Ask where data is stored, who can get in, and how to get it out.
- PIPEDA or your provincial law applies, and you stay responsible for data in cloud tools.
- Use unique passwords, a password manager, and two-step verification, starting with email.
- Give staff their own logins and remove access the day they leave.
- Keep three copies, on two kinds of storage, one away — and test restores.

Your four-week rollout and monthly routine

This plan spreads the work over four weeks. It is a schedule to help you plan, not a promise of where you will be at the end. Your business may need longer, or you may want to pause in a busy season. Move tasks around to suit you.

CHECKLIST

Week 1 — Take stock and decide

- [ ] Do the paper audit and choose your first target
- [ ] Read the CRA's record-keeping guidance and book a chat with your accountant
- [ ] Choose where your files will live

Week 2 — Build the system

- [ ] Create your folders, including 99 Inbox, and print the naming rules card
- [ ] Set up scanning on your phone or scanner
- [ ] Set up a password manager and two-step verification
- [ ] Start capturing receipts the same day

Week 3 — Go digital going forward

- [ ] Move quotes and invoices to email or invoicing software
- [ ] Ask regular suppliers to send bills by email
- [ ] Set up your first backup and log it
- [ ] Do your first weekly filing session

Week 4 — Tidy up and set the routine

- [ ] Do a first backlog session on the most recent year
- [ ] Set up a labelled box for paper you keep
- [ ] Fill in the retention notes sheet and do a test restore
- [ ] Book the monthly routine as a repeating appointment

Bringing staff and your bookkeeper on board

A paperless system only works if the people who touch paper use it.

- **Explain the why**: fewer lost receipts, less searching, safer customer information.
- **Keep it simple.** Show exactly what each person does — "photograph every receipt before leaving the store and send it to this address" — and nothing more. Put it on one page in the vehicle or by the till.

- **Ask for feedback.** The person who does the job every day will spot problems you miss.
- **Agree on a handover with your bookkeeper**: what you send, when, and in what format, or whether they get access to a shared folder or your accounting software.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a three-person renovation crew in Fredericton. Crew members photograph each receipt before leaving the store and send it to a shared receipt address, with the job name in the subject line. On Fridays you file them and check them against the card statement.

The monthly routine

Book an hour near the start of each month:

1. Empty the 99 Inbox and file everything with correct names.
2. Download last month's bank, card, and payment processor statements.
3. Check every charge on your card statement has a matching receipt file.
4. Run your backup and note it in the backup log.
5. Box last month's scanned paper, labelled by month and year.
6. Review who has access to your files and tools, and remove anyone who no longer needs it.
7. Check for updates on your devices.

Once a year, also test a restore from your offsite copy, review your retention notes with your accountant, and securely destroy paper you have confirmed you no longer need.

Expect the routine to slip now and then, especially in a busy season. When it does, do not try to catch up on everything at once. Empty the inbox folder, make sure this month's receipts are captured, and run a backup. Those three steps protect the records that matter most. The rest can wait for the next quiet week.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Treat the four-week plan as a flexible schedule, not a deadline.
> - Build the system before you tackle the backlog.
> - Give staff simple written instructions and agree on a handover with your bookkeeper.
> - Keep a monthly routine for filing, statements, backups, and access.

Templates and worksheets

Print these pages or copy them into a document or spreadsheet, and change them to fit your business.

Paper audit worksheet

WORKSHEET

Paper coming in (bills, receipts, statements, mail, cheques, signed forms)

Item	How often	Could it be digital?	Keep original?
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Paper going out (quotes, invoices, contracts, forms, letters)

Item	How often	Could it be digital?	Who handles it?
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Paper stored (cabinets, boxes, binders, vehicle, home)

Where	What years	How much	Notes
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

My first target: _____

Questions for my accountant: _____

Folder structure

TEMPLATE

[Business name] — Files

- 01 Admin — registrations, licences, insurance
- 02 Sales — [Year] / [Year-Month] — quotes, invoices, contracts
- 03 Purchases — [Year] / [Year-Month] — bills, receipts
- 04 Banking — [Year] — statements
- 05 Tax — [Year] — GST/HST, income tax, CRA letters
- 06 Payroll — [Year] — pay records, remittances, T4s
- 07 Staff — [Employee name] — restricted
- 08 Customers — [Customer name] — files, signed forms
- 99 Inbox — new scans; empty every week

Bookkeeper can open: _____

Staff can open: _____

Naming rules card

TEMPLATE

Pattern: Date_Who_What-Number.pdf

Date: year-month-day (2026-11-04) · **Who:** vendor or customer, no spaces · **What:** Invoice, Receipt, Quote, Contract, Statement, Letter · **Number:** invoice or reference number

Examples: 2026-11-04_Vendor_Invoice-1234.pdf · 2026-11-06_SmithJ_Quote-Q0412.pdf

Rules: underscores between parts, hyphens within. No spaces or symbols. No “final” or “new” — use v2, v3. Not sure? Put it in 99 Inbox.

Our vendor spellings: _____

Scan-day checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Phone lens or scanner glass clean; staples and sticky notes removed
- [ ] Settings: PDF, text recognition on, colour or greyscale for faint items
- [ ] One batch at a time (one month or one folder)
- [ ] Each scan readable: date, vendor, total, tax, GST/HST number
- [ ] All edges and pages present, right side up
- [ ] Each file named with the naming rules and moved out of 99 Inbox
- [ ] Originals boxed by year and month; nothing shredded unless confirmed on the retention notes sheet
- [ ] Backup run after a big session

Security checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Unique, strong password on every business account
- [ ] Password manager set up for owner and staff
- [ ] Two-step verification on email, cloud storage, banking, accounting, and payment tools
- [ ] Recovery codes stored safely, away from devices
- [ ] Every device locks automatically, updates automatically, and is encrypted
- [ ] Each staff member has their own login; sensitive folders restricted
- [ ] Changes to payment details confirmed by phone
- [ ] When someone leaves: access removed the same day, shared passwords changed, devices and keys returned, files moved to shared folders

Backup log

WORKSHEET

Copy 1 (working): _____ · Copy 2 (second storage): _____ · Copy 3 (away): _____

Date	What was backed up	Where	Restore tested?
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Retention notes sheet

Fill this in after you check the CRA's guidance and talk to your accountant. It is for your own notes, not a substitute for advice.

WORKSHEET

Record type	Keep how long?	Original needed?	Source
Sales invoices	_____	_____	_____
Purchase receipts	_____	_____	_____
Bank statements	_____	_____	_____
Tax returns, CRA letters	_____	_____	_____
Payroll and employee files	_____	_____	_____
Contracts and leases	_____	_____	_____
Asset records	_____	_____	_____

Destruction log

Date	What (type and date range)	How	By whom
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Remember: this guide is general information, not legal, tax, or accounting advice
- [ ] Complete the paper audit and choose my first target
- [ ] Read the CRA's guidance on keeping records and imaging
- [ ] Ask my accountant the record-keeping questions
- [ ] Choose cloud storage using the questions in this guide
- [ ] Keep business and personal files in separate accounts
- [ ] Create my folders and 99 Inbox, and print the naming rules card
- [ ] Set up scanning and capture receipts the same day, whole receipt
- [ ] Send quotes and invoices digitally with gap-free numbers
- [ ] Match payments to invoices and file statements monthly
- [ ] Check with a lawyer before using e-signatures on important documents
- [ ] Collect only the personal information I need; keep marketing consent separate
- [ ] Turn on two-step verification, starting with email, and use a password manager
- [ ] Lock, update, and encrypt every device
- [ ] Give staff their own logins, limit access, and remove it when they leave
- [ ] Keep three copies, on two kinds of storage, one away; test a restore
- [ ] Keep important originals in one safe place
- [ ] Shred only what I have confirmed I no longer need, and log it
- [ ] Brief staff and agree on a handover with my bookkeeper
- [ ] Book the monthly routine as a repeating appointment

Where to learn more

Official sources

- **Canada Revenue Agency** — canada.ca/revenue-agency. Search “keeping records” for how long to keep records, electronic records, and imaging, and for GST/HST input tax credit documentation.
- **Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada** — priv.gc.ca. Guidance on PIPEDA for businesses, including safeguards and cloud services.
- **Your provincial privacy office**, if you are in Alberta, British Columbia, or Quebec.
- **Canadian Centre for Cyber Security** — cyber.gc.ca. Plain-language security guidance for small organizations.
- **Your province’s government website** — for employment standards, consumer protection, and any provincial record rules. In Nova Scotia, start at novascotia.ca.

Talk to a professional

- **Your accountant or bookkeeper** — how long to keep each record, whether your scans are good enough to destroy originals, and how to hand over records.
- **A lawyer** — e-signatures on important documents, digital waivers, contracts, and privacy questions about sensitive information.
- **An IT professional** — if you have several staff, sensitive data, or are unsure how to set up access, backups, or device security.
- **Your bank or payment provider** — what protections they offer against payment fraud, and how long to keep deposited cheques.
- **Your insurance broker** — whether your policy covers lost or damaged records, stolen devices, or cyber incidents, and what they would expect you to have in place.

When you book a conversation with any of these professionals, bring your paper audit worksheet and retention notes sheet. They give a quick picture of how your records work today and make the conversation more focused.

> NOTE
>
> Rules, software, and services change. Check the official source for current rules and the current version of any tool before you rely on it. This guide is general information, not legal, tax, or accounting advice.